

THE SHE LIST

ADMINISTRATION

THE BUCK STOPS HERE

Madhabi Puri Buch, *57*
Chairperson, Securities and Exchange Board of India

VERY EARLY IN LIFE, Madhabi Puri Buch got clarity about what mattered to her the most—creating an impact in whichever field of work she chose. Soon after completing her MBA from IIM Ahmedabad, she worked for a year with an NGO to see if her management skills would make a difference there. But NGOs weren't as organised then. So, in 1989, she took up an offer from ICICI, then a development institution supporting manufacturing in a big way.

There, she was mentored by top banker K.V. Kamath, for whom, Madhabi recalls, the gender or age of a person did not matter, as long as they delivered the goods.

As ICICI evolved into a bank, Madhabi had new responsibilities coming her way. And her immediate boss handed down a lesson she would never forget. "I was told that unless I made friends with technology," she says, "I wouldn't be going anywhere in the firm." The message struck her deeply and cemented her determination to master technology from then on.

In five months, Kamath consulted the same boss before Madhabi was entrusted with the responsibility of launching icicidirect.com, one of India's earliest online trading platforms. That marked her entry into the capital markets. She could witness first-hand how technology was changing the way people did their business. "It could democratise and empower the smallest person in the market."

ACCOMPLISHMENT
Has leveraged data and technology to create better stakeholder consultation and easier tracing of malpractices

After a wholesome career with leadership roles in multiple private companies, a big turning point came when Madhabi was appointed whole-time member at SEBI in 2017 and took over as chairperson in March 2022. "We have now adopted data very vigorously even for policymaking," she says. Technology is leveraged in identifying wrongdoing such as insider trading or market manipulation among listed companies and enforcing action. Madhabi is also credited with spearheading many initiatives, including those related to reviewing and upgrading archaic laws.

It would not have been easy for Madhabi to manage the multiple leadership roles without her family's backing. That includes husband Dhaval, a former Unilever executive, and her mother-in-law. Madhabi recalls how she was always a big support, especially as she had a young son to look after. "I'm not fond of cooking, and she always defended me, saying it's fine.... She was proud of me as a professional." For now, being a regulator ever under the public gaze, framing strict laws and their timely enforcement remain her biggest challenge. ■

–M.G. Arun

WORK WISDOM

"Choose jobs and assignments with measurable outcomes and then...deliver on them!"

UNWIND TIME **On weekends, loves to binge-watch all kinds of OTT shows, including those on cookery**